

proceed with the agreement.

Q. Do you want the Government to kill the deal?

A. The Left does not want the Government to proceed with the agreement.

Q. And if they do proceed? Are you prepared for elections?

A. If this is the issue they want to break up with us on, all political parties need to be prepared for elections any time.

Q. The Left has always opposed the nuclear deal. What has surprised observers is the show of unity in the Opposition across party lines. Was there coordination between the Left and other parties?

A. While the stand of the Left parties has been consistent, NDA and UNPA have also raised objections to the nuclear deal. We discussed the matter with UNPA and found that we have common views. As for coordination, we have been in constant touch with them.

Q. Is the Centre's foreign policy tilt towards the US an irresolvable matter between the Left and the Congress?

A. The Left is not in favour of India forging a strategic alliance with the US. We expect the Government to go by the common minimum programme (CMP), which talks of pursuing a closer engagement and relations with the US, but not a strategic alliance. We have problems both with the Indo-US Defence Framework Agreement and the joint statement issued during the prime minister's visit to Washington in July 2005.

Q. You also disagree with the Government's position on Iran.

A. On Iran, we have been urging the UPA Government to not go by US perceptions. The Bush administration raised the nuclear issue regarding Iran just as it declared that Iraq had weapons of mass destruction. Now, with the National Intelligence Estimate of the US saying that Iran had stopped any efforts at a weapons programme in

2003, India should take heed and review its position. Along with the nuclear deal, foreign policy issues were also discussed by the UPA-Left committee. We hope this will resolve some of the problems.

Q. Given the ideologically divergent positions, why did you support the UPA Government for three-and-half years?

A. Support to the Congress-led coalition Government has been on the basis of the CMP and a joint commitment to fight communalism. There have been differences on economic policy, but we have sought to resolve them within the framework of the CMP. The main political and ideological threat stems from communal ideology and politics. It is on this basis that CPI(M) worked out its electoral line in the May 2004 Lok Sabha elections. While extending support to the Congress-led

that of BJP and the Congress.

Q. Many see Nandigram as the party's hour of shame. Has CPI(M)'s image been hurt by the violence?

A. The incidents in Nandigram and the way they have been projected in the media have caused some damage to our party's image. But we are confident that when the full truth about what has happened there since January 2007 comes out, people outside West Bengal will also understand there has been a political combination to convert the issue into a struggle against the Left Front Government. Eventually, people will understand that Nandigram was not a struggle about land.

Q. How did you get attracted to Marxism?

A. When I was in Madras Christian College, I began to read a lot on Karl Marx and his philosophy and from there it began.

THE INCIDENTS

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Government, we have not hesitated to demarcate our position on policy matters. This is what was decided in our last party congress held in April 2005.

Q. Is the Indo-US nuclear agreement the biggest flashpoint?

A. It is true that the nuclear issue became a focal point this year. But despite the media portraying it as a great clash, we have sought to engage the Government in discussions on the nuclear deal.

Q. Is there any real hope for a non-Congress, non-BJP third alternative? Will the Left support UNPA in and after the next polls?

A. Yes, CPI(M) looks forward to the formation of a third alternative in the country. But such an alternative cannot be seen purely as an electoral alliance. We still strive to get a policy-based platform, which can be distinct from

Q. Even after 60 years of Independence, 77 per cent of India's people cannot spend more than Rs 20 a day. Why?

A. Even as the urban-rural divide is growing, we have failed to tackle the agrarian crisis, which is serious. There has been a sharp increase in social and economic inequalities. The growth that we are experiencing is leading to a huge concentration of wealth. Today, India boasts of producing the most number of billionaires in Asia. The lesson to be learnt after 60 years of Independence is that we have to change the whole trajectory of development.

Q. What is CPI(M)'s agenda for the party congress to be held in Coimbatore in March next year?

A. The 19th congress to be held in Coimbatore will discuss the main questions India and its people face, and possible alternative policies. We will critically review the work done since the last congress of 2005. We shall also discuss the perennial question of how to broaden the base of the party and strengthen the party organisation.

THE LEFT PARTIES

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